

have good jobs, mortgages almost fully paid up, and money in the bank. They feel guilty about their good fortune while their own children suffer. But when parents jeopardize their own financial health in the name of helping their children, they're just courting financial disaster down the road. They're putting their own retirement in jeopardy. It'll come back to haunt them later.

I direct these next few paragraphs toward adult children who've moved home and are taking advantage of their parents' goodwill, living at home for free, cashing their checks, eating their food. Your parents don't seem to have the guts to tell you this, but *they don't really want you to move back home. Not because they don't love you. They do. But because they can't afford it.* Their focus should be on their financial health and socking away enough for their retirement. Not on keeping you comfortable and happy. That's *your* job.

And here's another truth, kids: Bunking in with your folks when the going gets tough deprives you of the chance to realize your potential and learn the important grown-up lesson of how to get through bad times. That's how true self-esteem is established: by doing estimable acts *for others*, not by hearing how amazing and wonderful you are from people who are going to say those things no matter what. By "failing to launch," as it's called, you never understand what it costs to be alive in your times. Therefore, you don't develop critical muscles you need to thrive in a bad economy. Sorry, I know a lot of things suck, and the economy is one of them right now, but you've got to work with it somehow.

If you haven't made the big leap backward yet, there are a few preventive measures you can take now. And don't kid yourself: Moving back home is a step in the wrong direction. Normally, I don't suggest that you borrow any money from family, ever, but your folks may rather lend you enough money to ride out a tough time than have you move back home. Offer to pay it back at a reasonable rate, with some interest. Moving is pricey. Use the loan to pay rent and bills, and meanwhile, work like a dog. Work like two dogs, in fact. Get a second job. But by all means, stop spending so much money.

Often, the chief reason young people get into dire financial straits right out of college is that they live as if they're making the kind of